HCP 1303 (cpc_--13_HU__HU_Jasz Arokszalas_jolanka-84): Feri to Jolánka Tóth

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

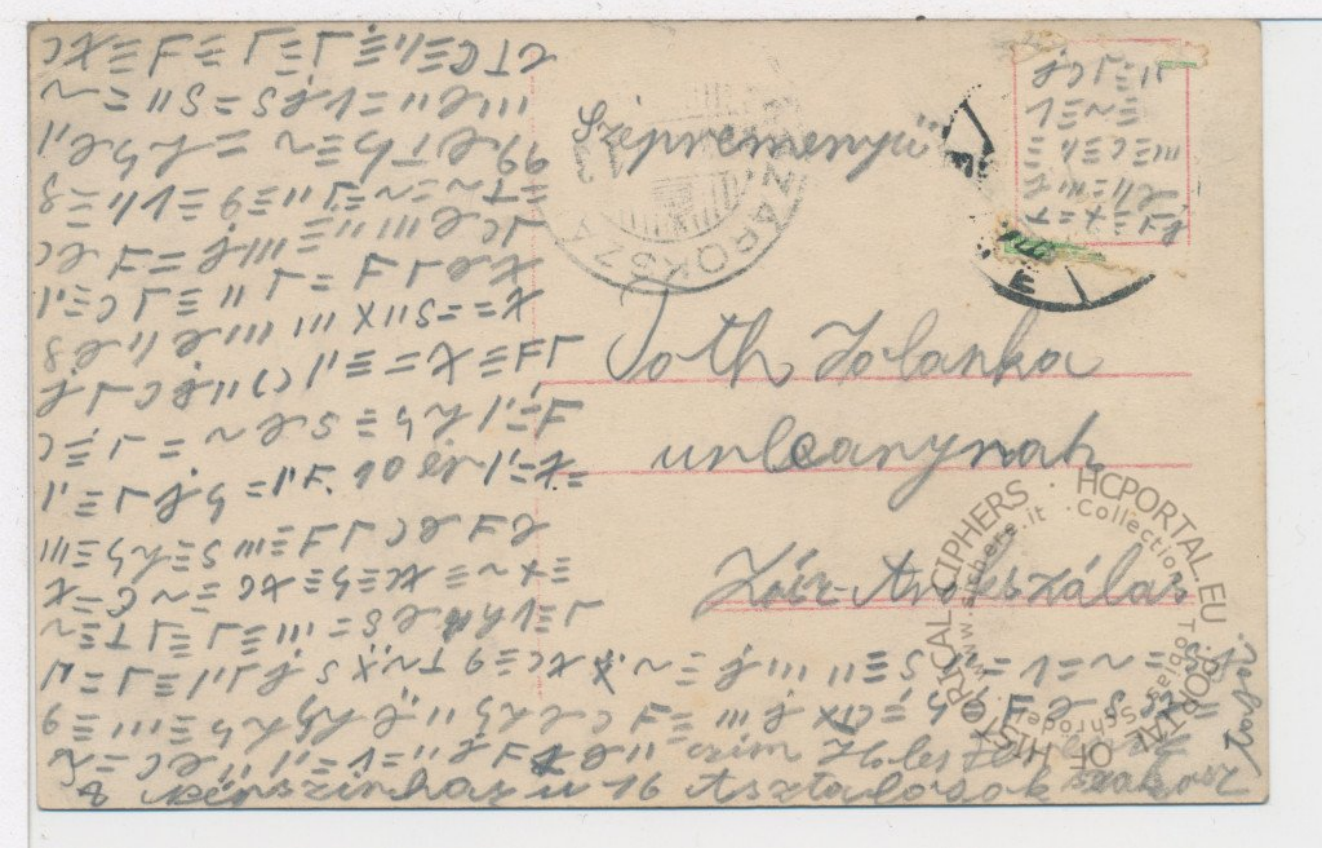
Status: all cipher text deciphered (16 rows and the 5 rows in the stamp box); independent review 1 verdict REVISE, findings addressed, no change to the cipher reading. Part of the plain pencil address remains unread. Report dated 2026-10-30.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1303 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1303), part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards. When captured on 2026-10-30 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard and T. Schrödel Collection, category Substitution, date and language unknown, location Europe, sender unknown, recipient Tóth Jolánka, with no transcription or solution attached.

The picture side carries only printed text (series 3601/02) and no cipher. The address side is written in pencil. It holds the plain address **Szépreményű Tóth Jolánka urileánynak, Jász-Árokszállás** ("to the promising young lady Jolánka Tóth"), sixteen cipher rows filling the left half and running along the bottom, five more cipher rows in the printed stamp box, and two plain lines at the bottom with a return address.

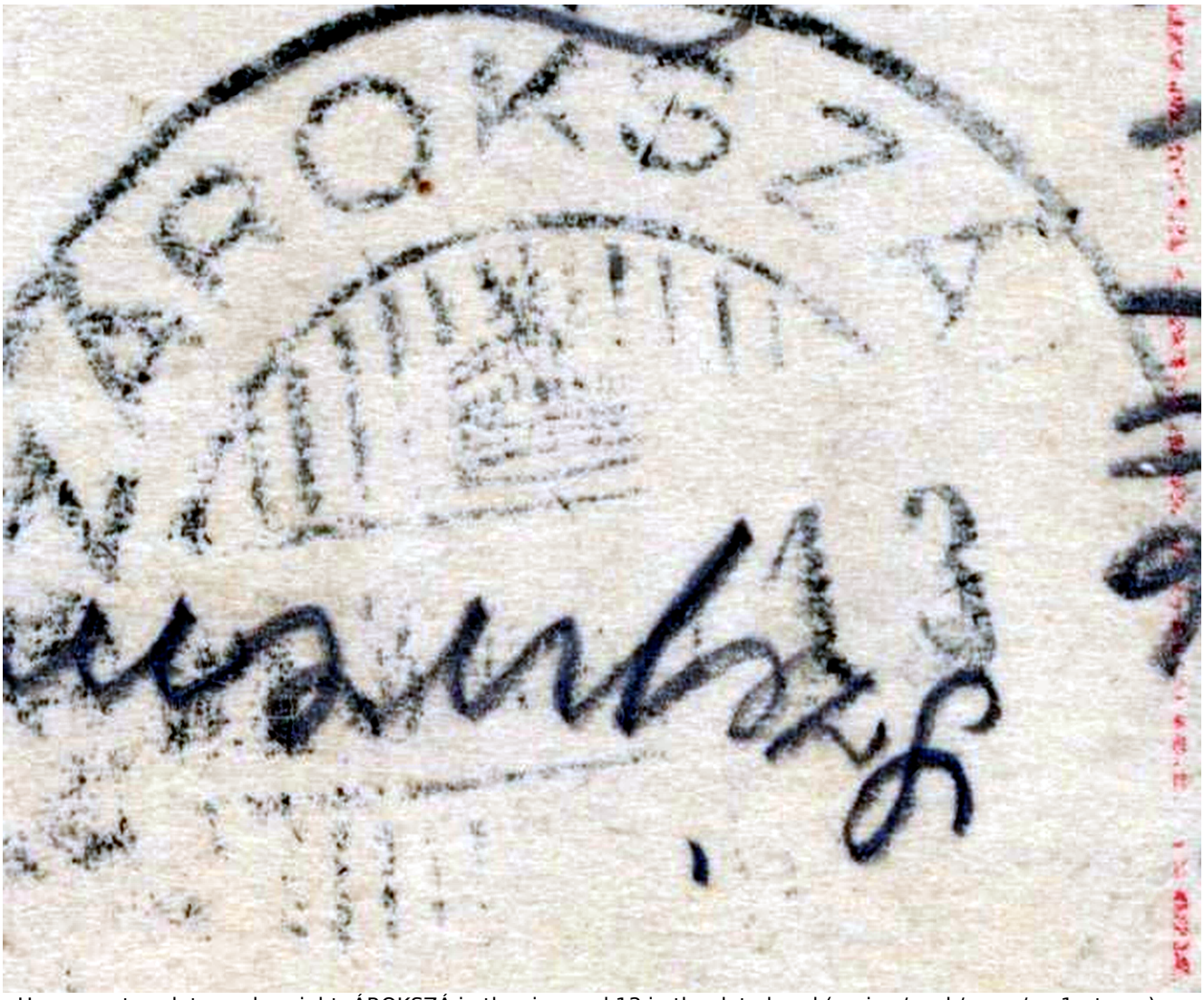
The card belongs to the "Jolánka" family, postcards to Jolánka Tóth in one Hungarian cipher, several signed Feri. Family cards HCP 1212 and 1243 are dated 1912 and HCP 1213 is catalogued 1913.



Address side: cipher rows at left and bottom, cipher in the stamp box, plain address at right (source/address-large.jpg)

Date evidence. The portal gives no date. The text gives only *Ápr. 10*, a future date for the writer. The card has two postmarks. The round postmark at the upper centre, upside down, reads …ÁROKSZÁ… in the ring and shows a clear 13 at the right end of its date band; the rest of the band is under the pencil word *Szépreményű*. A second, heavy cancellation rings the torn stamp, with an

E-like letter and an A in its arcs; its office is not established. 13 may be a year or a day. The portal name cpc_--13_ points to a day, because sister names hold the date in that slot as year-month-day (cpc_1912-05-17_, cpc_1913--_), but that is only the cataloguer's reading. No year is claimed here.



Upper postmark turned upright: ÁROKSZÁ in the ring and 13 in the date band (review/work/crops/pm1rot.png)

Method

The key was **transferred** from the finished family cards, chiefly the legend in ciphers/hcp-1216/SOLUTION.md; it was not recovered from this card. The legend also holds for HCP 1212, 1213, 1217, 1218, 1243 and 1301.

The transcription is **manual**, read sign by sign from enlarged crops of the un-converted original scan, and recorded in work/ledger.txt. It was made while reading for sense, so it is not blind. The first rows gave *szeretet édes Jo|lánka kívánom hogy a legjobb* at once. Harder passages were settled by rereading the crops: taking the h/p sign as p gave *egy pár hétig … ápr.*, and the end of row 14 resolved to *ha valaki*. The signs under the portal watermark stay visible through it.

The reviewer made its own crops, including a red-channel version to weaken the brown watermark, wrote its own sign-class transcription and its own statement of the key, and decoded them with its own script: 275 signs, all 21 rows equal to the ledger apart from accents and plain insertions. That check was not blind either, since the reviewer had read the ledger first, but each row was compared with crops.

Key

Simple monoalphabetic substitution with invented graphic signs. The labels are conventional names for the handwritten shapes.

Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter
two bars	a	section mark / S-curve	k	F-like	r
six	b	wave	l	right bowl	s
opposed bowls ( )	cs	three short strokes	m	gamma/corner	t
short + long stroke	d	two short strokes	n	plain cross x	u
three bars	e	cursive loop	o	chevron (1-shaped)	v
upright cross +	f	tall stroke + short tick	h / p	low descender	y
open loop with descender	g	dotted crossed curve	i	crossed diagonal	z
inverted T	j				

Dots over x and over the loop give ü and ö; a tick marks an accent. *gy* is written g + y. Word spaces are not written. Plain, unenciphered parts are the address, `10 er` inside row 10, the two bottom pencil lines, and a short word up the right edge.

Plaintext

Literal decipherment, row by row (h = the h/p sign, <. . .> = written in plain):

```
01 szeretetedesjo          09 sétalokegyhar
02 lankakivanom            10 hetigahr.<10><er>haz.a
03 hogyalegjobb            11 megyekmertsoro
04 kedvebentalálja         12 zasleszegeszelfe
05 soraimenmost            13 lejtetemakonyvet
06 hestentartoz            14 hatehtiküljbeszüleimnekhavalaki
07 kodommunkaaz            15 bemegygyöngyosremíujságárokszá
08 itsincsheazert          16 lasonhavanírjon
stamp box: isten | vele | edesem | imado | jaferi
```

Normalized Hungarian (word division, accents, spelling and bracketed restorations are editorial):

Szeretett édes Jolánka! Kívánom, hogy a legjobb kedvében találja soraim. Én most Pesten tartózkodom. Munka az itt sincs, de azért sétálok egy pár hétig. Ápr. 10-ér[e] hazamegyek, mert sorozás lesz. Egész elfelejtettem: a könyvet, ha teh[e]ti, küld[je] be szüleimnek, ha valaki bemegy Gyöngyösre. Mi újság Árokszálláson? Ha van, írjon.

Isten vele, édesem! Imádója, Feri. (stamp box)

Plain pencil: Cím: Holes Fe[…], [4 or 8] Népszínház u. 16, Asztalosok szak[…]

English translation: **My beloved sweet Jolánka! I hope my lines find you in the best of spirits. I am now staying in Pest. There is no work here either, but I shall still stroll about for a couple of weeks. By 10 April I am going home, because there will be the draft (army conscription). I quite forgot: the book, if you can, please send it in to my parents when someone goes in to Gyöngyös. What is new in Árokszállás? If there is anything, write.**

Farewell, my darling! Your adorer, Feri.

Address: Holes Fe[…], [4 or 8] Népszínház utca 16, Joiners' [trade] sec[tion…].

Slovak translation: **Moja milovaná, sladká Jolánka! Želám si, aby Vás moje riadky zastihli v tej najlepšej nálade. Teraz sa zdržiavam v Pešti. Práca nie je ani tu, ale aj tak sa ešte pár týždňov poprechádzam. Do 10. apríla idem domov, lebo bude odvod (branci). Celkom som zabudol: knihu, ak môžete, pošlite mojim rodičom, keď niekto pôjde do Gyöngyösu. Čo je nové v Árokszállási? Ak je niečo, napíšte.**

S Bohom, drahá! Váš ctiteľ Feri.

Adresa: Holes Fe[...], [4 alebo 8] Népszínház u. 16, stolári, odb[or...].

Notes on the reading:

- *Sorozás* is the army recruitment levy. Gyöngyös is a real town near Jász-Árokszállás, and *Árokszáláson* in cipher agrees independently with the plain address.
- *Cím* ("address") introduces the writer's return address. HCP 1309 has the same formula with the cipher signature *Holes Feri*, so Holes is in all likelihood his surname. There the first letter is open and rests on this card, and here the capital is itself uncertain, so the two cards support each other without proving it.

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1303/work/decode.py
```

It checks the SHA-256 of the four image files, decodes the ledger, and prints the literal rows and the normalized text. It uses only the Python standard library and writes no files.

Uncertainties

Calls resting on word sense, not on shape alone:

- **h/p sign.** p in *Pesten*, *pár* and *ápr.*; h elsewhere.
- **Row 8 *de*.** The first sign is of the h/p class, not the d of *édes*. *De azért* is the only sense; HCP 1216 has the same irregularity.
- **Row 14, first sign.** A hooked variant of h, read from *ha teheti*.
- **Row 13.** The sign before *a könyvet* is read as m. The n of *könyvet* is a dark overwritten blot of two strokes, and the o shows no dots.
- **Row 16.** The first sign, a wave running into a long descender, is taken as l of *Árokszá|láson*. The j of *írjon* is overstruck, with its base stroke visible.
- **Both f signs.** The f of *elfe-* (row 12) and of *Feri* (stamp box) are not the upright cross of the table but a slanted x with an arm or a tilted cross. Both are read from the word.
- **Under the watermark.** The a of *Árok-*, the h of *ha valaki* and the run r-o-k-s-z-a stay visible through the print; the bar count in *Árok-* rests partly on the name.
- **Stamp box.** The first sign of *Imádója* is faint and undotted, and the bottom bar of the e of *Feri* is broken.

Editorial changes: *szeretet* → szeretett, *it* → itt, *lejtetem* → -ttem, *tehti* → teh[e]ti, *külj* → küld[je] (the form is not certain), stray dots dropped, accents mostly supplied. The plain `10 er` is at least *10 ér*; the final e of 10-ér[e] is supplied.

Plain text not fully read (not cipher text):

- The capital of *Holes* has a crossbar and foot stroke, closer to this writer's J than to an obvious H. The next word begins *Fe…*, plausibly *Ferencz* or similar, with its ending lost under the portal stamp.
- The mark before *Népszínház* is a 4 or 8. Népszínház utca lies in Budapest's district VIII from general knowledge, so 8 is a candidate; this was not checked in a source.

- After *Asztalosok* comes *szak…*, overwritten; a trades section is plausible, not established. A short word up the right edge (T, o, then uncertain) is unresolved.

Context: the full postmark date, the office of the second cancellation, and the year of the card are not established. That this Feri is the Feri of the other family cards is suggested, not proved. No search for a prior publication was made beyond the portal status and the AI Decipherment Register (no record on 2026-10-30).

Review summary

Reviewer: a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent, round 1, verdict **REVISE**. The reviewer ran the reproduction command, read every row from its own crops and decoded its own transcription; it found no sign that changes a word. Its findings concerned context and disclosure, and all were addressed:

- **Postmarks (major).** The solver had wrongly written that the card has no date evidence. Both postmarks and the 13 are now described.
- **Surname.** The cross-reference to *Holes Feri* on HCP 1309 is added.
- **Plain lines.** *Holes* is now capital-uncertain, the next word is *Fe[…]*, and the mark before *Népszínház* is 4 or 8.
- **Sign notes.** The f of *elfe-* is disclosed as sense-based, and *gy* is recorded as two signs instead of one (ledger changed, decoded text the same).
- **10 er.** The supplied final e is now bracketed.

No letter of the cipher reading changed. The portal-name point on the date was added by the solver after the review.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1303, all three tabs, captured 2026-10-30: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1303 (source/metadata.md).
- Scans: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3969/ (picture side) and https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3970/ (address side), converted copies in source/, originals in work/hires/.
- Family key: ciphers/hcp-1216/SOLUTION.md; sister card ciphers/hcp-1309/SOLUTION.md.
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-10-30.